

country's most exciting and progressive composers. In the second, he left Russia following the Revolution and spent most of the next two decades abroad, establishing a worldwide reputation. The third phase saw his return to spend his later years in his homeland, where he was seen as a cultural hero but fell foul of the repressive Soviet regime.

Prokofiev was born in the village of Sontsovka, Ukraine, into a comfortable middle-class family. His father was manager of an agricultural estate and his mother was a talented amateur pianist. Two elder sisters had died as infants and he was brought up as an adored only child. He began piano lessons with his mother when he was four and within a year was writing his own pieces for the instrument. At the age of 10, he composed his first opera, performed by relatives and playmates, and in 1904 he passed the entrance examination for the St. Petersburg Conservatory.